

Carolina Raptor Center Offers Rehabilitation To Injured Birds Of Prey

The regal birds perched above the interstates are easy to spot this time of year, after the leaves fall and frost beats back the kudzu.

They're among my favorite winter sights on trips up I-77 or I-85. They sit in the tops of bare poplars, like kings on thrones, lording over us mere mortals.

Fascinating, isn't it, that a 20-inch bird waiting for a mouse to happen by can make a person feel downright insignificant?

The birds are red-tailed hawks, and they're one of the success stories

among birds of prey.

Other majestic birds have suffered because highways and subdivisions and shopping centers have destroyed habitat. But red-tailed hawks are open-country birds, and they've learned that mice thrive in the acres of lespedeza along the road banks.

That's just one lesson I learned on a recent visit to the Carolina Raptor Center at Latta Plantation Park on Mountain Island Lake.

I also learned I might be able to place abandoned eggs in the nest of the red-tailed hawk that makes her home at the edge of the woods behind my house. The center sponsors such projects.

I'd like to do that.

The Carolina Raptor Center was born at UNC-Charlotte. It was incorporated in 1981; it moved to the

See CENTER Next Page



**Allen
Norwood**



DAVIE HINSHAW/Staff

Pat Marcum, director of the Carolina Raptor Center, with friend Sigmund, a red-tailed hawk.